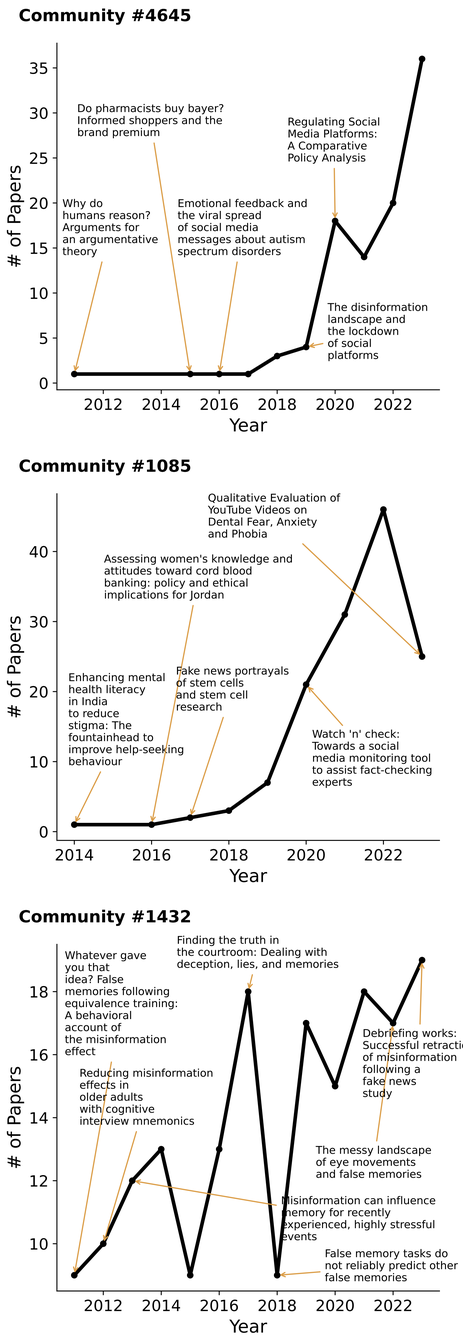
False memories to fake news: The evolution of the term “misinformation” in academic literature

Alejandro Ruiz, Danny Benett, Julia Zimmerman, Christopher M. Danforth, Peter Sheridan Dodds

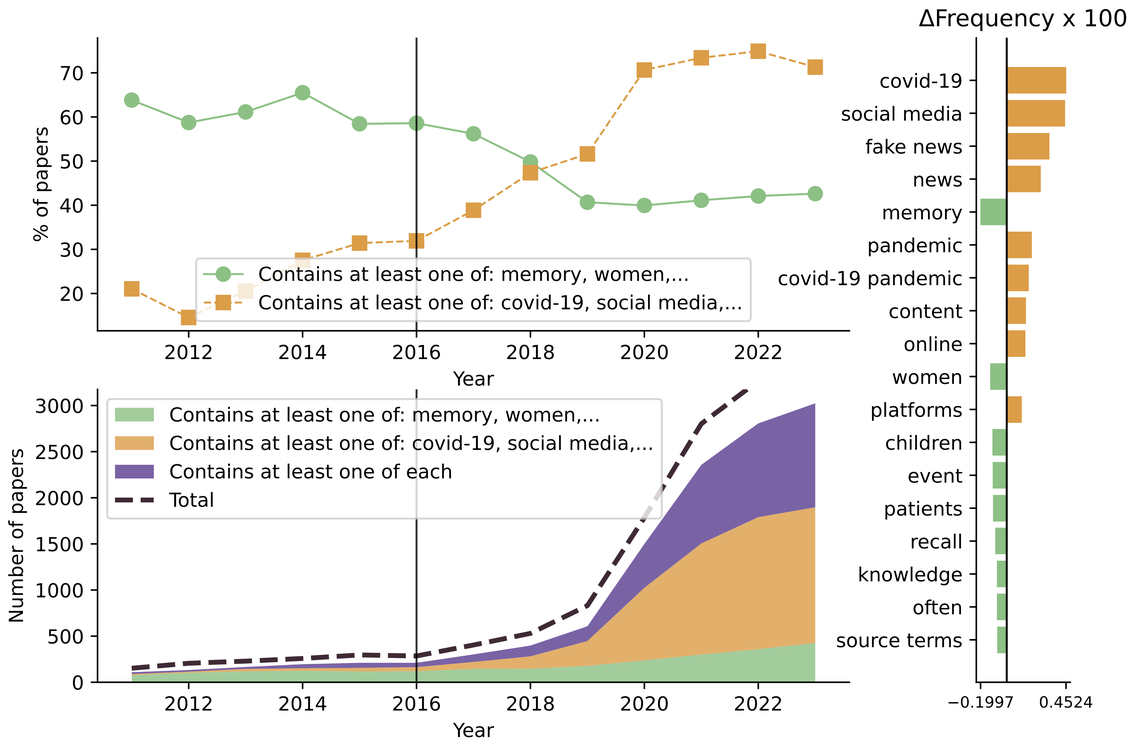
Computational Story Lab, Vermont Complex System Center

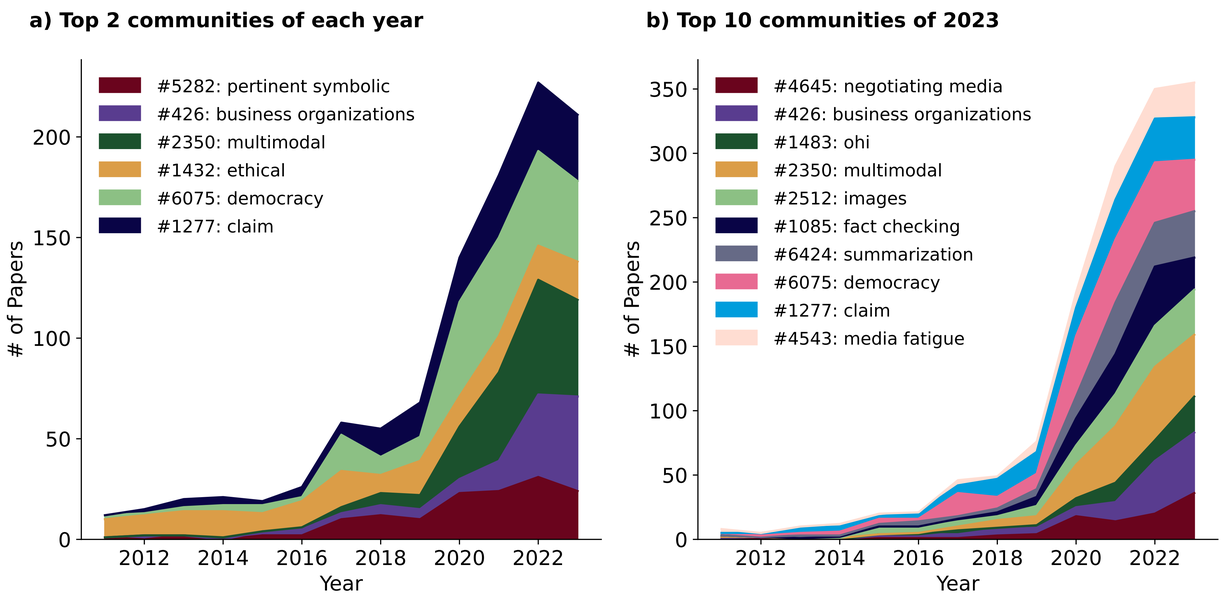
Birth of the post-2016 paradigm

- The post-2016 paradigm brings together many strands of research, one of which goes back to the “misinformation effect” and the Satanic panic

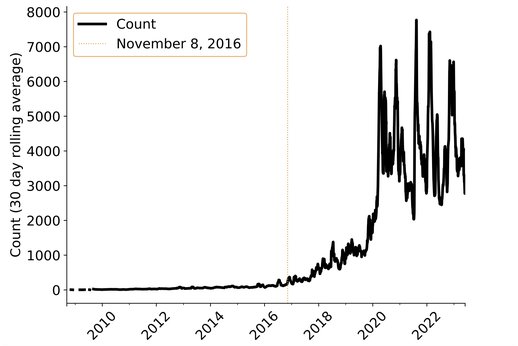


The **misinformation paradigm** studies people making, reading, and sharing **false statements**, usually on **social media**. It often produces research warning of the harm to society resulting from the sum of many such events.





Twitter usage of “misinformation”



Theoretical Problems

- **No theory of medium**: Misinformation paradigm sees through the medium, often discussing **direct** user interaction
- **Zombie laboratory model**: The core model from misinformation effect research is detached from its real world phenomenon
- **Lack of emergent theory**: Paradigm contains untenable theoretical commitment to evaluating individual pieces of information

Conclusion

- Public relations, military propaganda, intelligence agencies, etc. operate in the chasm between true and false, rather than at its poles
- The more likely that a piece of misinformation is to be believed, the more difficult it necessarily is to detect as misinformation
- Untenable theoretical commitments force misinformation scholars to focus their inquiry precisely on the least salient part of the phenomenon

https://arxiv.org/abs/2602.22395